India's participation in the conference did not cut ice with Tehran. The then Iranian President Akbar Hashemi Rafsanjani's refusals to entertain Pakistan's calls to isolate India made Islamabad boycott the conference.[96] About a week earlier, Indian president K. R. Narayanan had visited Tehran to discuss Afghanistan and Kashmir and found a receptive audience.[97] Pakistan's refusal to include India on Afghanistan directly impacted India's stance on engagement with the Taliban. Salman Haidar, then India's foreign secretary, who attended the conference with Vivek Katju, says India was actively excluded on Pakistan's insistence while the US went along.[98] This meeting in Tehran, however, was the 'only meeting' in those days which was critical and was based on a common cause between India and Iran. Even then, 'we [India and Iran] had interests, but we did not have that many options'.[99] Haidar's successor, Raghunath, concurs that in his meetings with the Iranians 'there was confirmation of our common interest that the Northern Alliance [United Front] needs to be helped and this whole threat to peace, security, and stability in Afghanistan must be countered.'[100] Pakistan's decision to refrain from attending the conference in protest at India's participation, according to the MEA, 'signified closer understanding between India and Iran on a crucial regional issue.'[101]

Occurring in the context of Tehran's bitter rivalry with Washington over the former's acquisition of nuclear reactors from Moscow, and Iran's denunciation of the Taliban as a US creation abetted by Islamabad; there were strong grounds for India-Iran bonding (something that Zia had actively tried to contain during the 1980s).[102] Rafsanjani's April 1995 visit and Iranian foreign minister Ali Akbar Velayati's January 1996 visit to India proved critical in cementing ideas on a variety of strategic issues. If diplomatic signals count for anything, India's keenness to develop links with Iran was clear in Rao's personal visit to receive Rafsanjani at the airport.[103] During his meeting with Rao, Rafsanjani extended support on Kashmir and sought India's support vis-à-vis Washington and on Afghanistan.[104] Rafsanjani's visit strengthened the perception of a US-Pakistan nexus that may be detrimental to India's interests. According to K. Subrahmanyam: 'Any Pakistani involvement in the containment strategy against Iran at the behest of the U.S. will destabilise a Pakistan which will have an openly acknowledged nuclear arsenal.'[105] Challenges emanating from an unstable